

Tantra of the Essential Meaning of the Mind of All the Tathāgatas

Sarvatathāgatacittagarbhārthatantra · Toh 412 · Derge Kangyur

ད་བཅའ་ཞི་གཤམ་པ་ཐམས་ཅད་ཀྱི་མེས་ཀྱི་སྤྱི་པའི་དོན་གྱི་རྒྱུ།

Toh 412 in the Kangyur is a tantra known in Sanskrit as the Sarvatathāgatacittagarbhārthatantra and in Tibetan as the Tantra of the Essential Meaning of the Mind of All the Tathāgatas. It belongs to the tantric section of the Kangyur and is a text concerned with the nature of the mind of all buddhas, centering on Vajrasattva as the embodiment of the gnosis body of the tathāgatas and exploring themes of enlightened mind, emptiness, and the relationship between existence and liberation. The text opens with verse exchanges involving Vajrasattva and the Blessed One, situating its teachings within a tantric dialogic framework characteristic of this class of scripture. It was translated into Tibetan from Sanskrit by the Indian master Gayādhara together with the Tibetan monk-translator Śākya Yeshé.

It is complete.

This was translated and edited by the Indian master Gayādhara and the translator, the monk Śākya Yeshé.

In the language of India: Sarvatathāgatacittagarbhārthatantra. In the language of Tibet: The Tantra of the Essential Meaning of the Mind of All the Tathāgatas.

Homage to glorious Vajrasattva. Homage to Mañjuśrī in his youthful form.

I, the vajra of the body, speech, and mind of all the Tathāgatas,
abide as the supreme essence, the body in which that essence dwells.

Behold Vajrasattva.

The gnosis body of the buddhas,
this mind endowed with manifold forms
is indeed free from all extremes,
yet it is widely proclaimed as existence and cyclic existence.

Then Vajrasattva addressed the Blessed One in these words:

Oh wonderful! Self-arisen Blessed One,
lord of space, body of manifold forms,
sovereign of speech, king of mantra and awareness,
born as light from the unborn expanse:

you who lead the six classes of beings have spoken,
and from your own mouth drops have fallen.
With kakuru crystal, emerald,
conch, rock-crystal essence,
and the five colors of precious gems,
you have adorned the gnosis palace with color.
From you yourself, and none other, arise the Wrathful One,
the faithful sons of the Victors who listen to the teaching,
and the retinues that tame beings.

Then, knowing the intent of the speech of the Blessed One Śākyamuni,
Vajrasattva performed the gathering of the wisdom-emanation, the outpouring
of the gnosis of all the buddhas. Thereupon the Tathāgata gave this express
declaration:

One who has not seen the great effortless bliss, the innate,
whatever striving and practice one may undertake,
is but a childish person spending energy without purpose.
To grasp at substances is itself bondage. To meditate on dependent
origination is the second.

Even the wish for experience without purpose is the cause of bondage — that
is the third.

Some smear themselves with the ash of the Śaiva mountain;
Īśvara collects substances of the sky.

That is the cause of bondage — the fourth.

This concludes the first chapter, the introductory chapter.

In a nature free from extremes,
how can the sickness of subject and object bind?
In a sky that is primordially pure,
how can habitual tendencies and signs bind?
In the nature of reality where arising and ceasing are absent,
how can the sickness of cause and effect bind?
In a wisdom beyond thought,
how can the sickness of conceptual analysis bind?

O wondrous! In the expanse of mind itself, utterly pure,
the innate, supreme bliss,
clear light, blissful in its manifold times,

in the bliss of the wheel of purity —
those with perverted intellect, constricted and wrong,
wander to the root of what is certain to produce existence.

Furthermore, the Teacher spoke these words:

To a student bound by attachment,
give the artificial remedy of great bliss.
To a student prone to anger,
give the artificial remedy of moving wind.
To one tormented by desire like fire by water,
give the artificial remedy of drawing and guiding one's own stream.
To one whose mind is utterly bewildered,
give the artificial remedy of emptiness and compassion.

When the Teacher had thus spoken, he gathered the retinue with perfect mastery, and they addressed the Tathāgata in these words:

Since it is primordially and completely pure,
how can there be cyclic existence in the three realms?
If something adventitious were to occur,
would it not have a beginning and an end?
Or might Vajrasattva and the rest
not be tormented in the hells?
If cyclic existence were established as blissful,
would purification be possible, or what would there be to do?

Having spoken thus, they disappeared. The Tathāgata declared:

You who listen to me, excellent!
Concentrate with one-pointed, joyful mind.
From the indeterminate colors of the rainbow
appear the distinct differences of families.
What is present is not the same as god or human.
What has not been gathered is complete in one.
The fearless lion of speech —
the intent of the word is supremely profound.
With an emerald intellect, catch the essence;
transform the many colors into their family.
It is like the swastika, for example.

It arises like the kāraṇḍa bird.
Examined and examined again, it continues to arise.
The wisdom body of the buddhas,
the all-pervading lord, the manifold forms of space —
today these arise within the bodhisattva's body.

The Protector of beings having spoken thus,
the assembly became gladdened
and gathered to one side,
then addressed the Blessed One with these words:

What is the nature of the view?
What is the nature of the unmodified?
What is the conduct of wisdom?

The Blessed One declared:

Excellent! O great assembled gathering,
the characteristics of the six aspects,
the seven distinctions and the illustrative examples,
the fourteen — in their respective forms,
the thirteen — are said to be without error.
The innate, pervading and abiding,
arises as the direct, empowered essence.
Turning back by generosity and looking,
descending from the sky, sustaining bliss,
downward through the six wheels in sequence,
the red bliss of the syllable A is received.
It is called wisdom, yet suffering arises.
Through delusion one grasps at sorrow and sin.
Not abandoning that becomes a cause of bondage.
Two monks in the manner of siddhas,
claiming complete empowerment, engage in pleasure.
At death they go to hell.
In Rājagṛha, a city of queens,
gathering in intimate contact,
one teaches and demonstrates wisdom to others.
At death one is born as a maggot in a charnel ground
in the womb of a prostitute.
In another world-realm, in a mind-hell,

one cries out in extreme torment.
Beside the prikṣa tree, O Akoṭa,
the mandate of the teaching is carried out in full.
Union itself is called wisdom —
it is well established for the fair-faced one.
At the passing of life, one is born crying.
That person of teaching is therefore certain.
What you ask, I shall explain.

The unmodified nature of mind —
one who does not understand, whose view perceives no object,
whose eyes shift — will that essence not pass away?

Having said this, the speaker vanished.
The first conceptual inquiry of the questioner was resolved.
The person of teaching again addressed:

O sole friend and guru of all beings,
what is the nature of the impact of the bond?
What is the nature of empowerment?

This was the second inquiry posed,
and here ends the second chapter, on the view.

As for the name given to innate bliss —
entering into meditative absorption,
the illustrative examples explained are as follows:

The black stacked lotus,
the gṛdhā, the kaṅka,
the pig, the young female elephant,
the moon and the crystal, the bull and the lion,
the Oḍa river mixed with three streams,
gold, mountain of space, and fire —
know the third group as fourteen.

One endowed with suchness is truly sublime.
Whoever transgresses beyond that
is said to be genuinely tormented in hell.

How wonderful! — the great fortune of self-awareness.
It blows into the clouds of the sky.

Children, not knowing their own nature,
expand and contract the unmodified nature.
Pure, luminous, unobstructed,
it enters the ocean of wisdom — through delusion
it becomes the knot of all-binding bondage,
and the stream of total bondage never ceases.

Even when the arrow of the innate is released,
through the erroneous intellect of those who grasp and aim,
the mind is corrupted by the one and the many,
and delusion spreads into pride.

The deity of the swirling movement of the wind —
through syllables and colors one comes to understand.
When mind and wind are in motion,
the cessation of appearance is wisdom.
That very thing, inverted, becomes the cause of bondage.

Brahmā's caṇḍālī (inner heat),
when kindled, dissolves the very deity into light.
From ka and the rest on the right, and A on the left,
the head-mark of the syllable, the words and their nourishment,
from the root-channels of seventy thousand,
what descends generates bliss.
One proclaims this to be the ultimate truth.
When delusion is gathered in, the knot is released.
When defilement arises, one becomes bound.

Through the principle of the innate,
one teaches others accordingly as appropriate.
I do not say that one becomes liberated thereby.

How wonderful! — the mind appears as two.
However one practices, liberation does not come.

Here ends the third chapter, on empowerment.

Then, in order to cut through the three forms of conceptual thought,
Vajrasattva rose from his seat and spoke thus, entering into meditative
absorption bearing the name of the Lord of Space, Variegated Body.

"Homage to you, Vajra-Brave One!
Homage to the vajra, the self-arisen mind!
All homages are the pure, luminous expanse.
Homage — I bow, homage — I bow!
Guru of beings, form of primordial wisdom,
drop of speech, innately born,
to the expanse of pure self-knowing awareness, I bow."

The Blessed One then declared: "Ah, bodhisattva, Vajra, listen! The supreme meditation is that which has become manifest — the warmth of wisdom, blazing variegated. If one sees whatever arises and realizes its nonexistence, then where there is no seeing, there is seeing. When one sees, it ceases; when one looks, it arises. The great light of wisdom and gnosis — if one rests in it as one pleases, bliss is blocked. In the ocean of wisdom, primordially clear, buddhahood is not cultivated.

Is there an antidote to it? The reasoning that teaches: the disease of bondage — does it teach the bliss of past, future, and present? Can you yourself, Vajrasattva, teach it? Or how does it stand?

It is beyond expression, and therefore free from words. It is beyond achievement, and therefore free from analogy. It is beyond indication, and therefore the path of speech is cut. Since it is innately born, it is beyond achievement. Since it has become manifest, it is beyond cultivation. Since it is beyond analysis, it is free from contrivance. It is realized by an undistracted mind."

When this chapter on meditation was being taught, even the teacher himself fell unconscious and collapsed to the ground. The asuras (demigods) and vidyādhara each reeled and staggered separately. A thousand groups of divine daughters gained the dust-free eye of Dharma — completely purified. Twenty thousand bodhisattvas immediately attained full awakening. Six world-systems trembled, with rumbling and resounding, making the three realms shake. At that very instant, Semdzogpa — Completeness of Mind — arose in wonder and spoke thus:

"How wondrous! Lord of all buddhas,
perfectly awakened, supreme bliss,
sole friend who tames the fortunate,
lamp of beings, gnosis-torch —
by the primordial wisdom of your mind

you have swept away the lingot of ignorance's door.
To you, pure primordial wisdom, I bow!"

With delight and rejoicing he offered this prayer, and all bowed down and took their places.

Here ends the fourth chapter, on meditation.

Then the Blessed One Śākyamuni looked upon Vajrasattva and gave this instruction: "Excellent! You great gathered assembly — by entering into genuine primordial wisdom, you are free from the disease of bondage in conceptual thought. Yet regarding the intrinsic nature free from extremes, when looked at through negation, one grasps at difference. The innate nature, the natural state — even that, when bound, what does one see? For one in whom that very suchness has become manifest, what hold can negativity have? For those dwelling in the world-systems of the three times, it bestows blessing upon them. If it were to have form, could it be measured or gauged? To gods, asuras, and those of the secret, it protects as is fitting. Even the yakṣas who have obtained great power will continually provide protection. Spirits, demons, and harmful forces will fully accomplish that one's intentions. Illness, flux, tumors, and contagion will not arise in that one's body. Obscurations accumulated over aeons will be purified in a single instant. Stream-enterers, once-returners, non-returners, and bodhisattvas of no-more-returning will see their splendor increase thereby.

Therefore, great bodhisattva, listen! The wheel of pervasion, supreme bliss — that very thing, endowed with the six perfections, the wordless, the speech of awareness — is capable of measuring the supreme meaning. It teaches how to measure the nature of reality through meaning."

It arises when one asks at the guru's lips;
when realized, that yogin
will come to reveal the dust-motes of the sky.
The base-born cling to the words of illusion.
Have they seen the innately born, or not?
If it is seen, it becomes an object of examination;
once examined, one is scattered and wanders astray.
In the mind of duality, nirvāṇa appears as sorrow.

The supreme wheel of great bliss,
which transforms all into a single color,

abides in the natural state — binding and liberation become one.
Those who know the kindness of the guru
are shown the very nature of unborn being.
One who does not know the gracious word of the guru —
what will that one see of the innately born?
By that innately born one is bound;
through it, wandering beings arise and are fettered.
Through conceiving things as separate, one falls into sickness.
Through reckoning time and place, one turns back.
Through viewing self and other, one turns back.
Through speaking of this life and the next, one goes astray.
Through altering the unborn and the innately born, one is bound.

Thus spoke the Blessed One.

The person who explains it praised it thus:

O wonder! The body of primordial wisdom, utterly pure —
the pervasive lord, the key that opens the gate of speech —
it has torn away the veil of ignorance.

The body of primordial wisdom of the Sugata —

O wonder! The vital essence of the mind of yoga,
it liberates beings from the torment of suffering.

Unborn, innately co-emergent, unceasing —
homage and praise to the awakening mind (bodhicitta)!

This is the fifth chapter, on the benefits.

Here ends the tantra of the essential meaning of the heart of mind of all the Tathāgatas.

It was translated and definitively established at Phamthing by the venerable guru himself and the translator Senkar Śākya'od.

Translator's Notes

- The phrase rendered "born as light from the unborn expanse" is literally "from the unborn expanse, the light-maker arose," where "light-maker" may be a kenning for the sun or for the emanating display of gnosis; the translation follows the doctrinal context of the tantra.

The epithet "Wrathful One" in the retinue passage translates a term meaning "the terrifying one," which in context likely refers to a wrathful emanation form; the precise identity is not specified in the passage.

The final image of the svastika is a traditional Indian symbol of auspiciousness and completeness, used here as an analogy for how a single form contains and generates manifold differentiation.

The "ash of the Śaiva mountain" refers to the practice of anointing the body with cremation ash associated with Śaiva ascetics; "Īśvara collects substances of the sky" refers to Śaiva esoteric rites involving ethereal or sky-born materials, here polemically cited as forms of bondage.

- The passage contains several highly technical and cryptic tantric terms whose precise referents are contested. The "six aspects," "seven distinctions," and groupings of "fourteen" and "thirteen" likely refer to classifications within this particular tantric cycle; no commentarial tradition has been identified here to anchor these numbers with certainty, and they are rendered literally.

"Kāraṇḍa" is a type of bird referenced in Indian literature, here used as a simile for the arising of something from within itself, akin to a bird hatching from its egg. "Prikṣa" is a tree name retained in transliteration; "Akoṭa" appears to be a proper name or place name of uncertain identification.

"Caṇḍālī" is the inner heat practice (Skt. caṇḍālī, also known as tummo), here attributed to Brahmā in an unusual formulation that may carry a specific ritual meaning within this tantric context.

The phrase rendered "the red bliss of the syllable A" follows the Tibetan "a ta rakta bde ba len," which blends Sanskrit syllables into the verse; this is a tantric technical usage.

The section describing two monks and the events at Rājagṛha reads as a cautionary narrative about the dangers of misapplied tantric practice, a genre well attested in tantric literature.

- The term rendered "Lord of Space, Variegated Body" translates namkha'i dagpo natshogs lus, which is the name of the meditative absorption Vajrasattva enters. This is a tantric samādhi name and its exact referent is context-dependent within this tantra's system.

The phrase "lingot of ignorance's door" renders ma rig sgo nga'i ling thog bsal. The compound ling thog is obscure; it likely means something like a latch, bolt, or impediment. The image is of a barrier at the door of ignorance being removed.

"Semdzogpa" is a proper name meaning "one whose mind is complete" or "perfection of mind," left as a name here since it appears to be a specific assembly member's name in this tantric context.

The line "dust-free eye of Dharma" follows the standard technical formula for stream-entry realization in Mahāyāna sūtra literature.

- The phrase rendered "the dust-motes of the sky" is a Tantric image suggesting the yogin's capacity to perceive or enumerate the infinitely subtle — it implies a supranormal perceptual power, not a literal meteorological claim.

"Transforms all into a single color" is a standard Vajrayāna idiom for non-dual integration, where all phenomena are unified in the single taste of great bliss.

The colophon names the translator as Senkar Śākya'od and the place of translation as Phamthing, a known translation site in the Nepal-Tibet borderlands associated with early transmission of tantric texts.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.